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SPACE



## Space Force bets on commercial entrants in \$4B satcom contest

American warfighters need jam-proof communications, and the Space Force is planning to spend hundreds of millions to ensure they have them.

As part of that effort, the service established the Protected Tactical Satcom program to build out secure battlefield communications via satellites. The Space Force has already awarded contracts to defense primes Boeing and Northrop Grumman to develop prototype payloads for satellites heading to far-away geostationary orbit.

Now, the program is entering a new phase. On Tuesday, the Space Force awarded five additional contracts for the design and demonstration of purpose-built satellites to provide jam-resistant comms to tactical forces. The winners include previous winners Boeing, Northrop Grumman, Viasat, and Intelsat, plus a relative newcomer: Astranis, a venture-backed startup based in San Francisco. (Intelsat will buy its satellite bus from K2 Space, another venture-backed startup.)

The initial awards are relatively small, totaling \$37.3 million combined. But the program has a \$4 billion award ceiling, so the winners could sign on to a much more lucrative defense deal.

Each firm will develop its architectures through January 2026. After that, the Space Force will select one design and award an additional contract for the

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first satellite, with a launch planned in 2028.

Additional production awards will be doled out, also in 2028.

The PTS-G contracts are a notable departure from how the military has historically procured geostationary satellites, which have typically had extremely long timelines from contract award to launch, and would cost hundreds of millions to over a billion dollars per spacecraft.

In contrast, the Space Force is clearly trying to leverage the speed of commercial entrants and encourage competition by selecting multiple vendors for the initial phase of the program.

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“Our PTS-G contract transforms how SSC acquires SATCOM capability for the warfighter,” program executive officer Cordell DeLaPena Jr. said in a news release. “The incorporation of commercial baseline designs to meet military capability significantly enhances the Space Force’s speed

and efficiency to add capability to meet emerging threats.”

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**Aria Alamalhodaei**

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Aria Alamalhodaei covers the space and defense industries at TechCrunch. Previously, she covered the...

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# Hubble Network plans massive satellite upgrade to create global Bluetooth layer



[Hubble Network's](#) satellite-powered Bluetooth network is getting a big upgrade.

The Seattle-based startup, which aims to bring to enterprises what Apple's Find My has brought to consumers, has built a powerful new phased-array receiver that will enable what Hubble CEO Alex Haro calls a "true Bluetooth layer around the Earth."

This advanced payload will fly on two massive new satellites from four-year-old [Muon Space](#), called MuSat XL, which are slated to launch in 2027. The first two MuSat XL spacecraft will deliver a 12-hour global revisit time and detect Bluetooth Low Energy (BLE) signals at 30 times lower power than current capabilities, Hubble says. If those numbers pan out, it could materially extend battery life for tracking tags and sensors here on Earth.

IMAGE CREDIT: MUON SPACE

Those two satellites will form the backbone of Hubble's BLE Finding Network for enterprises in sectors ranging from logistics, infrastructure, and defense.

Hubble [made history in 2024](#) when it became the first company to establish a Bluetooth connection directly to a satellite. The startup's proposition is compelling: Instead of needing to buy specialized hardware, customers will only need to integrate their devices' chipsets with a piece of firmware to enable connection to the Hubble network.

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The benefits of the space-based network are massive, Hubble argues: It can provide visibility across the globe, including in remote areas, and offers a developer-friendly way to let companies track assets without building any additional infrastructure.

The company currently has seven spacecraft on orbit with a target of having 60 satellites in operation by 2028. The long-term goal is to upgrade the entire constellation to the larger platform buses because of their power and performance upgrades, Haro said.



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It's an aggressive schedule, but Haro added that one reason Hubble chose to partner with Muon is the latter's ability to rapidly scale manufacturing to hit this goal, despite being a young company. (A recent [\\$146 million funding round](#) should help.) Gregory Smirin, president of Muon Space, told TechCrunch that the company's San Jose production facility is being built out to support

production of over 500 spacecraft per year by 2027.

Hubble is the first customer for the 500 kilogram-class MuSat XL satellite platform, which Muon says can provide multi-kilowatt power to payloads, optical crosslinks, high-volume downlink, and “near real-time” communications for time-sensitive missions. The partnership also signals a bigger push by the company to compete for more lucrative contracts with the Department of Defense.

The XL platform “is a perfect size and capability for SDA Tranche missions,” Smirin said, referring to the Space Development Agency’s initiative to build out a missile defense constellation in low Earth orbit. “XL reflects both the evolution of our technical stack and our growing role in delivering the kind of multi-mission spacecraft that programs like SDA increasingly rely on.”

Muon’s business model can be thought of as [space-as-a-service](#): The company designs, builds, and operates satellites using a vertically integrated stack of hardware and software. The stack, called Halo, is meant to open up space access for companies with promising payloads but no interest in building the underlying satellite architecture. In practice, that means Hubble can focus on developing the BLE network while Muon handles the satellite platforms and mission operations.

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## Rocket Lab eyes big defense opportunities with new acquisition

Aria Alamalhodaei — 2:23 PM PDT · August 7, 2025

Rocket Lab is signaling to investors, yet again, that it's more than “just” a rocket company.

Rocket Lab's second-quarter results, which were posted Thursday, show revenues continue to be

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driven by its space systems business rather than launch. The results also highlighted the company's acquisition strategy and how its purchase of a new optical payloads company will make it more competitive for lucrative government contracts.

The company's space systems brought in \$97.9 million of the \$144.5 million in total revenues for the second quarter. Rocket Labs' total revenue, its highest quarterly revenue in the company's history, jumped 36% from a year ago. The company's net loss widened to \$66.4 million.

Rocket Lab founder and CEO Peter Beck highlighted the "busy quarter of M&A activity" as the company gets close to closing its deal to buy [Geost](#), a company that builds optical payloads. Through that acquisition, which will close at \$275 million in cash and equity, Rocket Lab is opening a new business unit called Optical Systems to scale electro-optical and infrared sensor manufacturing.

Those sensors are used in missile warning, tracking, and space domain awareness. The acquisition is also one part of a larger play from Rocket Lab — spelled out quite explicitly in the company's earnings presentation — to bid for multibillion-dollar [DOD initiatives like Golden Dome](#).

Rocket Lab has already won some major defense contracts, including a \$515 million, 18-satellite build contract to support the Space Development Agency's constellation of missile-tracking satellites. The company has moved into production on those satellites, following confirmation that they meet the DOD's mission requirements, Rocket Lab said.

Down on Earth, Rocket Lab says it's progressing well toward the first launch of its larger Neutron rocket. The rocket's launch complex in Virginia is

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expected to be complete in the third quarter of this year, with [hardware en route](#) and the new rocket engine, called Archimedes, undergoing multiple tests per day.



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The company is staying vague about the exact launch date, saying only in the presentation that it is pushing an “all-out effort to get Neutron to the launch pad before the end of 2025.”

Rocket Lab ended the quarter with \$564 million in cash and cash equivalents and estimates revenues will hit between \$145 to \$155 million next quarter.

Topics: [earnings](#) [Mergers and Acquisitions](#)

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AI



OpenAI is practically giving ChatGPT to the government for free

OpenAI is poised to undercut rivals like Anthropic and Google in the race to see its AI tools integrated into federal agency workflows.

The AI giant has [reached an agreement](#) with the U.S. General Services Administration (GSA), the government's central purchasing arm, to offer ChatGPT Enterprise to participating federal agencies for just \$1 per agency for the next year.

The partnership comes a day after the [GSA added OpenAI, Google, and Anthropic](#) to a list of approved AI vendors that can offer their services to civilian federal agencies. The companies will see their tools offered via the Multiple Award Schedule (MAS), a federal contracting platform that lets government agencies access AI tools via pre-negotiated contracts so they don't have to negotiate with vendors individually.

It's not clear whether other AI firms are going to offer their services at such a discounted rate, though GSA Federal Acquisition Service commissioner Josh Gruenbaum in a [statement](#) encouraged "other American AI technology companies to follow OpenAI's lead and work with us."

TechCrunch has reached out to Anthropic and Google for more information.

In addition to access to ChatGPT Enterprise, OpenAI is offering unlimited use of advanced models for an

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additional 60 days. Federal employees will also have access to a new government user community and tailored introductory training resources to get familiar with OpenAI's tools.

Data security is a top priority for government agencies that are concerned about sensitive information being leaked into model training sets. TechCrunch has asked the GSA for details on how government data is being safeguarded, including whether measures like on-premises or private cloud deployments are being used to enhance security.

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"The government is taking a cautious, security-first approach to AI," a GSA spokesperson told TechCrunch. "This ensures sensitive information remains protected while enabling agencies to benefit from AI-driven efficiencies."

OpenAI's discount comes a couple of weeks after the Trump administration published its AI Action Plan that seeks to boost data center buildouts and

integrate more AI tools into government, among other things. It also follows a Trump executive order that [bans “woke AI”](#) and AI models that aren’t “ideologically neutral” from government contracts.

TechCrunch has reached out to OpenAI to learn more about its GSA partnership and how it will approach Trump’s executive order.

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Rebecca Bellan is a senior reporter at TechCrunch where she covers the business, policy, and emerging trends...

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